

# Blocking Storyboard

*Every move, entrance, exit and light change — the picture and the line it lands on. Six Characters in Search of an Author · Village Players, Lausanne · dir. Kiarash Jamshidi*

## HOW TO USE IT

- **One card = one moment.** Read top to bottom, in order, act by act and part by part. The text beside each picture is the verbatim line from the script where the move happens — nothing added.
- **The picture is the stage from above.** The audience sits at the bottom edge (↓). Everyone on stage in that moment is placed as a labelled dot. The move is drawn from a **solid dot** (where the character starts), along a **dashed arrow**, to a **hollow ring** (where they end). A **burst** marks a sudden event — the veil, the revolver, the gunshot.
- **Doors are labelled on the frame** — the gaps in the wall. Entrances and exits run to and from them, and each tag names *which way*: *enters · door at back · USC, EXIT · unhurried, out of the office · SL, to the wings · SR, leaves toward the house · downstage*.
- **The light is named on every card** — the badge top-right, and the floor is tinted to match the cue. The set is drawn per act: the chair-circle (One), the two-level platform with shower column, piano and pegs (Two), the fountain with the Manager's table and its bare bulb (Three). □ is the Boy-chair, ◇ the Child-bundle.

## ORIENTATION — WHICH WAY IS WHICH

The audience sits at the foot of every map (**downstage**, DS); the back wall is the top (**upstage**, US). Because the actors face the house, the actor's right — **stage-right (SR)** — is the *left* of the page, and **stage-left (SL)** is the right. So *USC* = upstage centre (the door at back), *SL* = the prompt side here (office, dressing rooms), *SR* = the opposite wing. Every entrance and exit names its direction.

## THE LIGHT CUES

|                 |                                                        |
|-----------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| HALF-DARK       | the bare work-light of an empty house, before the play |
| WORK LIGHT      | full white rehearsal light                             |
| REHEARSAL       | the light brought down for “Mixing It Up”              |
| AMBER WASH      | the tenuous light of the Six                           |
| DEEP RED        | as they cross off to the office                        |
| SHOWER          | the tight overhead column on one figure                |
| CURTAIN ↓ / ↑   | the curtain falls / rises                              |
| FOUNTAIN + BULB | only the fountain glow and the bare bulb               |
| BLACKOUT        | full dark — the gunshot                                |
| LIGHTS SNAP UP  | the snap back after the shot                           |

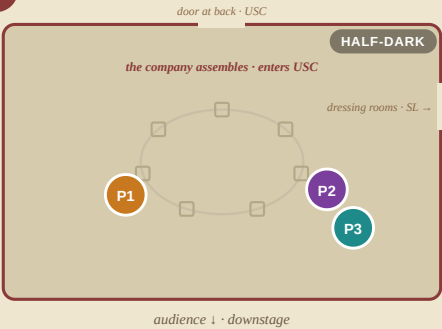
## WHO IS WHO

|             |             |                  |               |                 |             |
|-------------|-------------|------------------|---------------|-----------------|-------------|
| F Father    | M Mother    | SD Step-Daughter | S Son         | MG Manager      | P1 Player 1 |
| P2 Player 2 | P3 Player 3 | MP Madame Pace   | BOY Boy-chair | CH Child-bundle |             |

# Act One — The Family

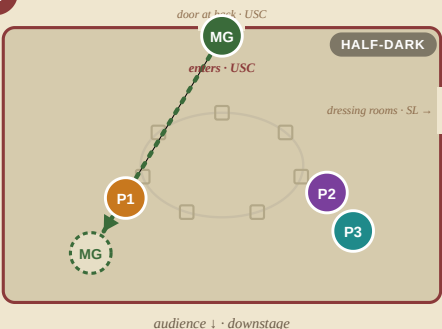
## PART I — THE REHEARSAL

1



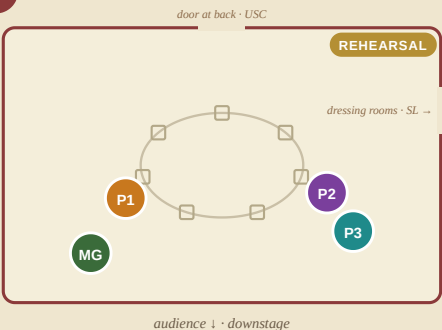
*[The Actors and Actresses of the company enter from the back of the stage: first one, then another, then two together; nine or ten in all. Some move off towards their dressing rooms. The Prompter, the “book” under his arm, waits for the Manager].*

2



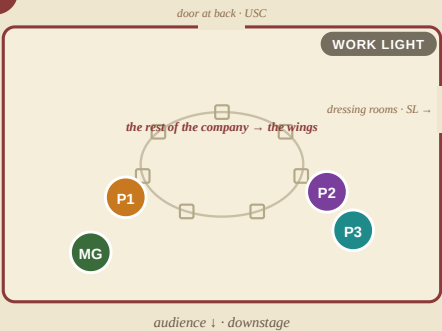
*[Finally, the Manager enters with the precise weariness of a man who has managed the Village Players too long; he goes to his table].*

3



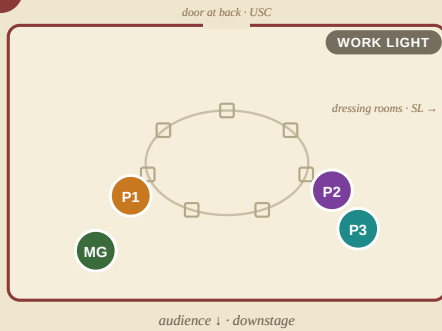
**THE MANAGER** *[to the Property Man].* A little light, please — if the house has any left to spare us this evening. **PLAYER 2** *[as Property Man].* Yes, sir. At once. *[A light comes down on to the stage].*

4



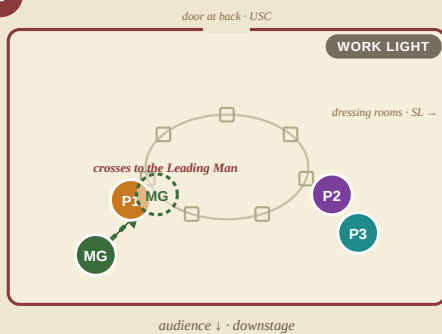
**THE MANAGER** *[clapping his hands].* Come along! Second act of “Mixing It Up” — and play it as if you wanted the public back for the third. *[The Actors go to the wings, all except the three who begin the rehearsal].*

5



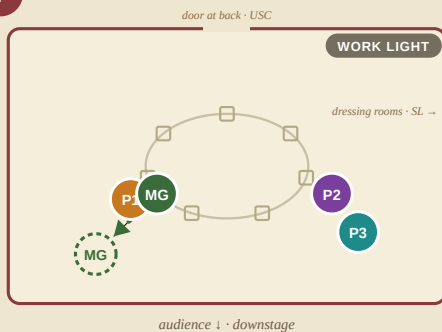
**PLAYER 1** [*as Ledding Man*]. Excuse me, but must I absolutely wear a cook's cap? It's ridiculous. I have a reputation in this canton — fifteen years.

6



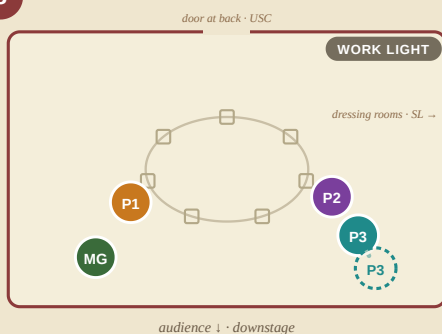
**THE MANAGER** *[jumping up in a rage, crossing to the Leading Man]*. Ridiculous? Is it my fault if France won't send us any more good comedies?

7



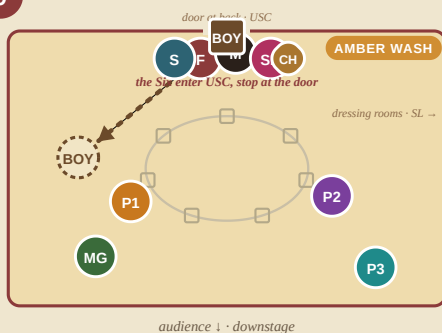
**THE MANAGER.** Wouldn't we all, sir. But let's get on with it. [*he goes back to his table*]

8



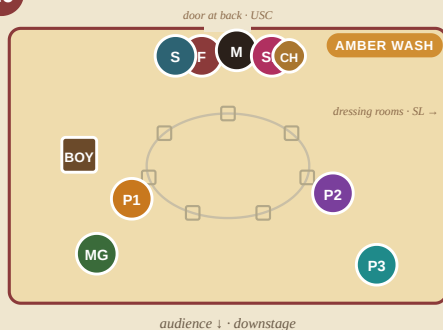
**PLAYER 3** [*as Prompter, getting into the box*]. Pardon, sir — may I get into my box? There's a draught off that door, and I'd rather not be hoarse for my first proper season.

9



*[The white working lights soften to a warm amber. The Door-keeper carries on the Boy-chair and sets it at the edge of the stage; the four live Characters — Father, Mother, Step-Daughter, Son — enter and stop by the door at back, the Step-Daughter carrying the Child-bundle].*

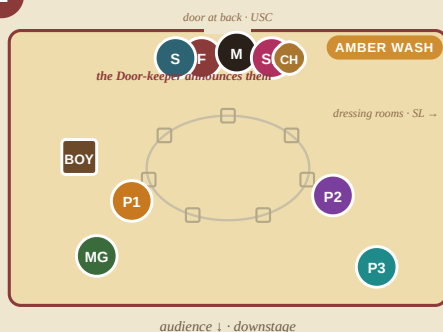
10



[A tenuous light surrounds the Six, almost as if irradiated by them. It will disappear when they come forward].

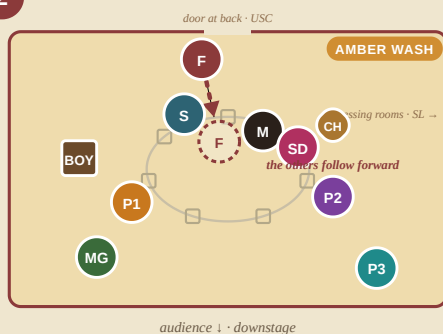
## PART II — THE INTERRUPTION

1



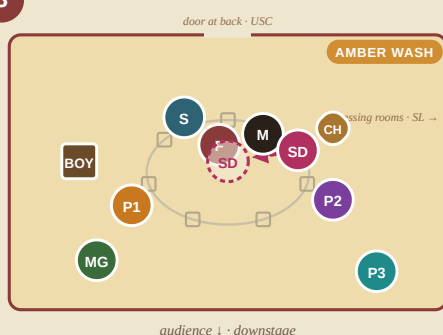
**PLAYER 1** [as Door-keeper, cap in hand]. Excuse me, sir — these people are asking for you; they insist on coming in. **THE MANAGER** [rudely]. I am rehearsing — no one is allowed in during rehearsals!

2



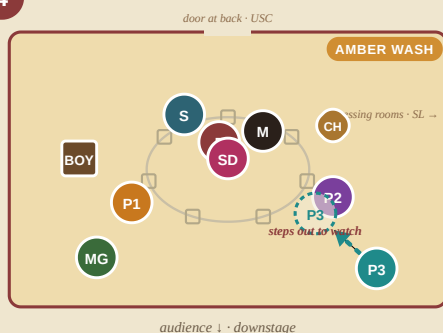
**THE FATHER** [coming forward, the others following, embarrassed]. No, for Heaven's sake, what are you saying? We bring you a drama, sir.

3



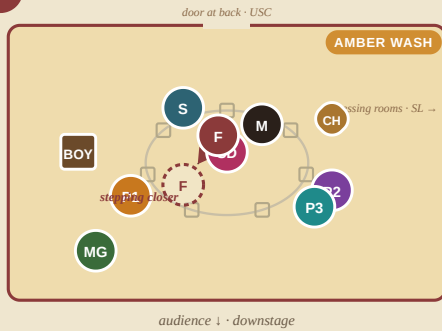
**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** [stepping in front of the Father, taking the line]. So much the better, sir. You can put us on tonight.

4



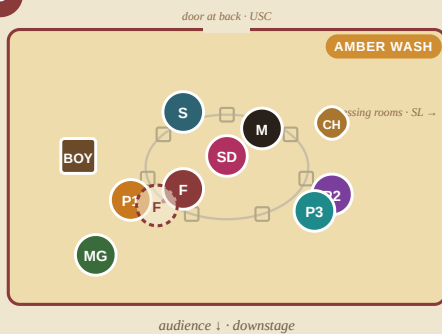
**PLAYER 3** [coming forward from the others]. Oh — do you hear that?

5



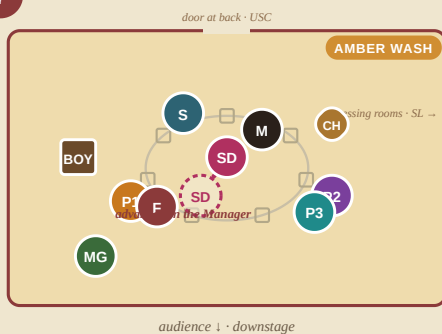
**THE FATHER** *[stepping closer, voice softening]*. You call us mad because we come without a book. But isn't that your work — to make invented things seem true? We are true already. We only lack the stage.

6



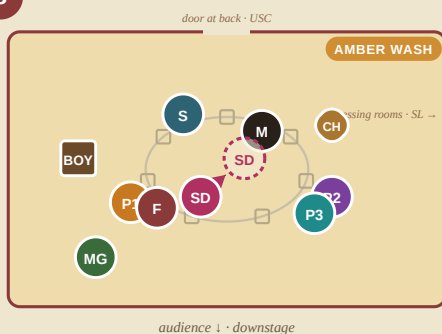
**THE MANAGER**. But what do you want here, all of you? **THE FATHER**. We want to live. **THE MANAGER**. For Eternity? **THE FATHER**. No, sir, only for a moment... in you.

7



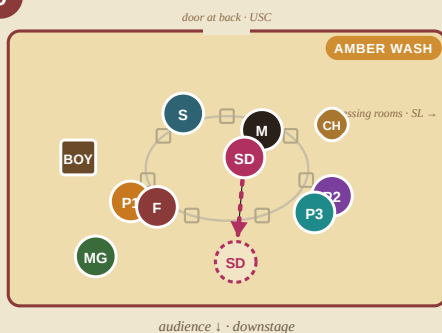
**THE FATHER** *[determined, coming forward]*. Your disbelief amazes me. Aren't you used to seeing the characters an author creates spring to life? **THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[advances towards the Manager, eyes level]*. We are really six most interesting characters, sir — side-tracked, however.

8



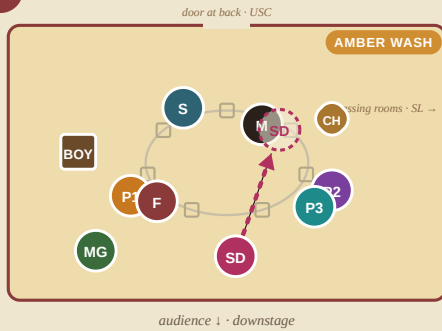
**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[crossing behind the Father; a hand on his shoulder, left one beat too long, then withdrawn]*. My passion, sir. Ah, if you only knew — my passion for *him*.

9



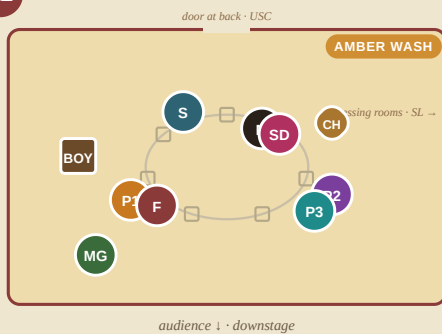
**THE STEP-DAUGHTER**. I, who am a two months' orphan, will show you how well I can dance and sing. *[Sings and dances Valentine]*.

10



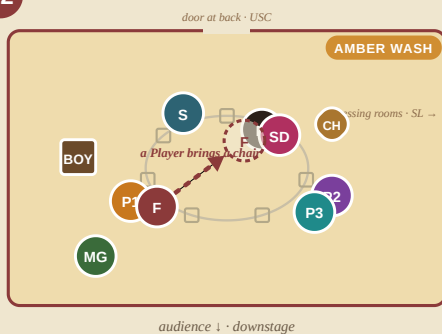
**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[goes to the Mother and embraces her]*.  
Stage this drama now, sir! At a certain moment, when we lose this  
little darling...

11



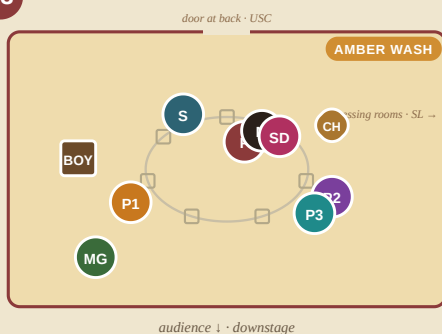
**THE MOTHER** *[one arm tightening round the Child-bundle]*. In the  
name of these two little children, I beg you... *[she grows faint]* Oh  
God!

12



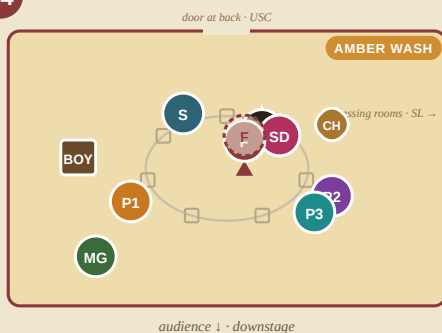
**THE FATHER** *[coming forward to support her; an Actor brings a  
chair]*. Quick, a chair, a chair for this poor widow!

13



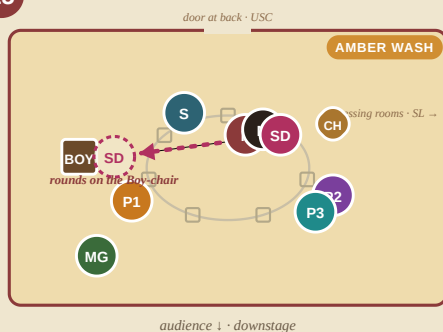
**THE MOTHER** *[rising and covering her face with her hands]*. I beg  
you, sir. Stop him. I cannot bear what he wants to do.

14



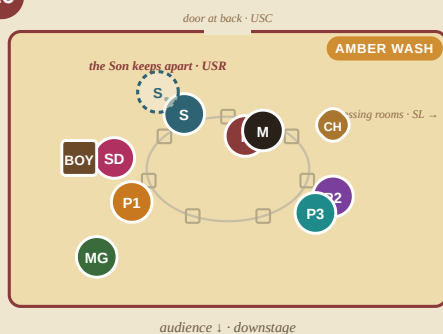
**THE FATHER** *[raising her veil]*. Let them see you!

15



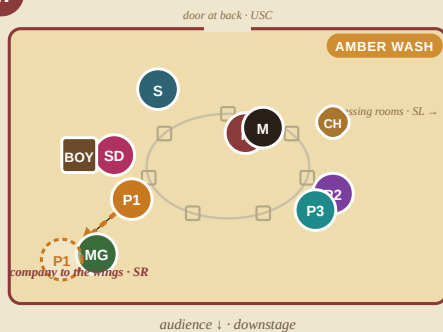
**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[turning on the Boy-chair, gripping the lapel of the coat as if shaking him]*. He was always full of affection and kindness for you.

16



**THE SON** [*hands in his pockets, body not moving*]. Leave me alone. I don't come into this. **THE FATHER**. What? You don't come into this?

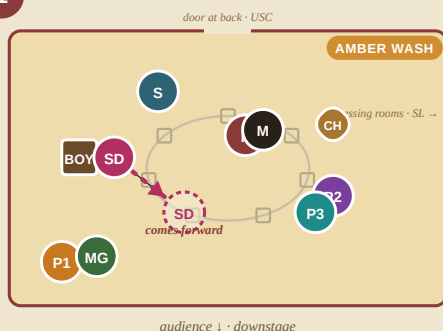
17



**PLAYER 1** [*as Leading Man, beginning to relish it — then his eyes reach the Mother, and the rest does not arrive*]. What a spectacle. What an absolute...

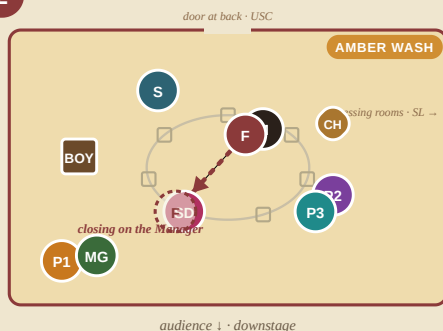
## PART III — THE BARGAIN

1



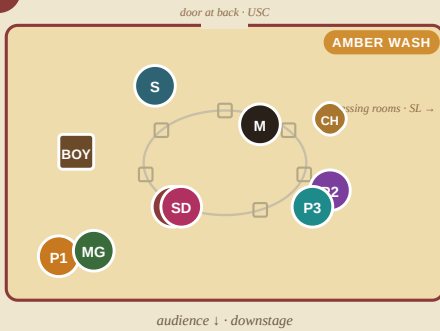
**THE MANAGER.** I begin to think there's the stuff for a drama in all this. **THE STEP-DAUGHTER** [*coming forward*]. When you've got a character like me. **THE FATHER** [*shutting her up*]. You be quiet!

2



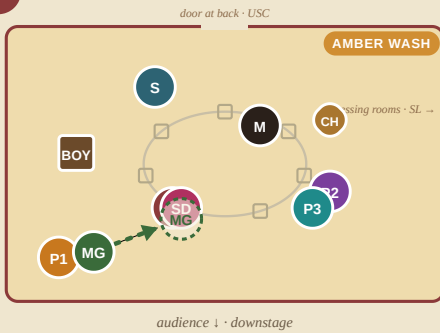
**THE FATHER** [*to the Manager*]. No, no — look here. You must be the author. **THE MANAGER**. I have never been an author. **THE FATHER**. Then why not turn author now?

3



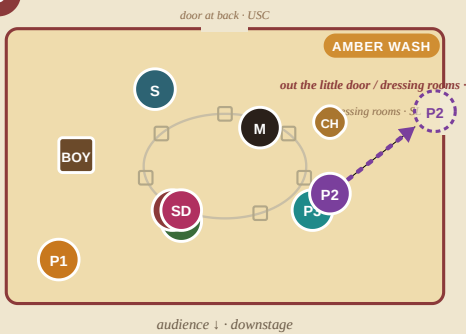
**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** The room — I see it. The window with the mantles, the divan, the looking-glass, a screen, and the little mahogany table with the blue envelope and its hundred francs.

4



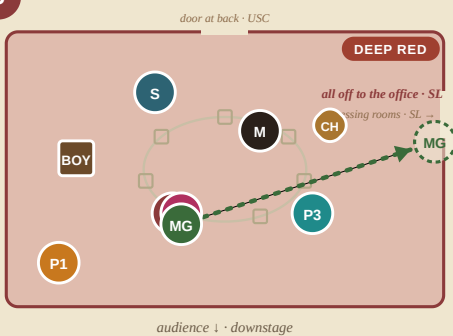
**THE MANAGER** [*moves away, then turning to the Actors*]. Yes, yes. Come on! Be punctual, please!

5



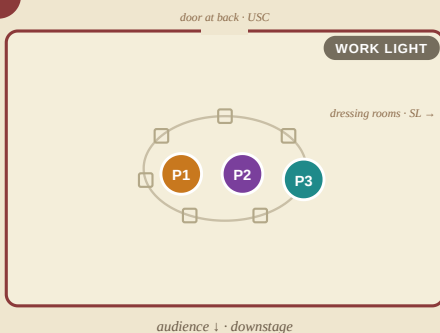
[*Thus talking, the Actors leave the stage; some going out by the little door at the back, others retiring to their dressing-rooms*].

6



**THE MANAGER** [*hooked; leading the Father and the Six off to his office*]. Come with me to my office. In a quarter of an hour, all back here again. [*They cross the stage and go off*].

7

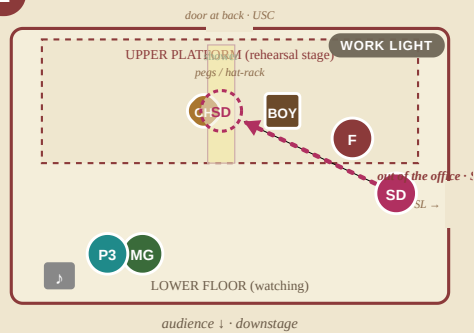


**PLAYER 1** [*as Leading Man*]. Is he serious? He has taken six strangers into his office and left us standing here like furniture. **PLAYER 2** [*as Leading Lady*]. Ordinary strangers do not arrive with a tragedy already rehearsed. **PLAYER 3.** Perhaps there is a play.

# Act Two — The Theatre

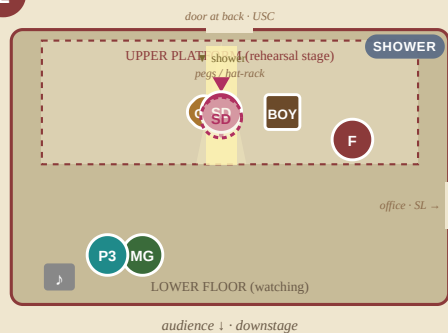
## PART I — THE SETUP

1



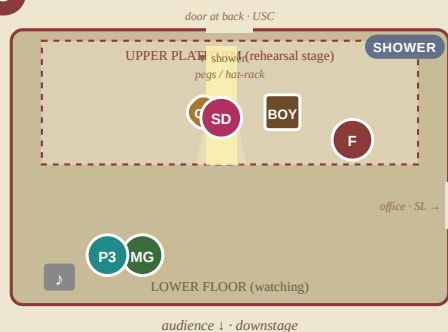
**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[comes out of the Manager's office carrying the Child-bundle and dragging the Boy-chair, and cries]:* Come on, Rosetta, let's run!

2



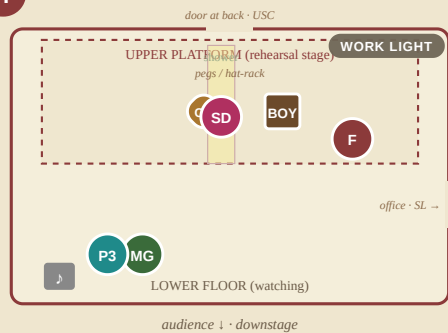
*[She drags the Boy-chair a little behind her and leaves it leaning. The stage darkens; the shower — a tight vertical column of light — falls on the Step-Daughter only. The pianist begins Satie's Gymnopédie No. 1, and she kneels with the Child-bundle].*

3



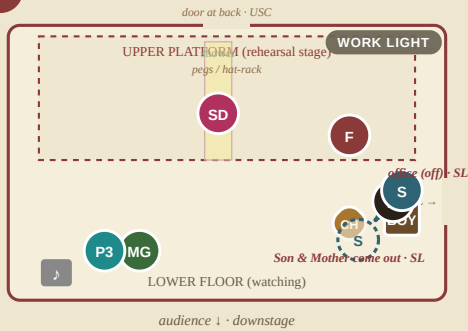
*[She slides her hand into the coat pocket and finds the revolver. She holds it up briefly in the column of light, then returns it to the pocket].*

4



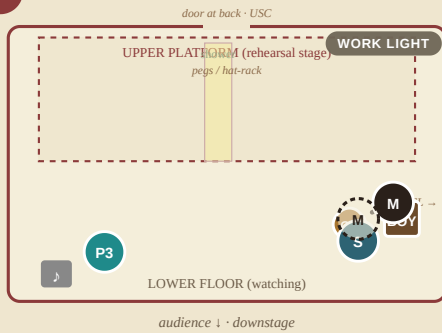
*[The piano dies on her last word. The shower releases; the working lights come up. The Step-Daughter is alone on the upper platform with the Child-bundle and the Boy-chair].*

5



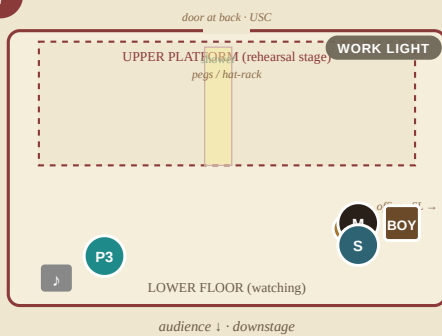
*[The Father, Manager and Step-Daughter go back into the office (off); at the same time the Son, followed by the Mother, comes out].*

6



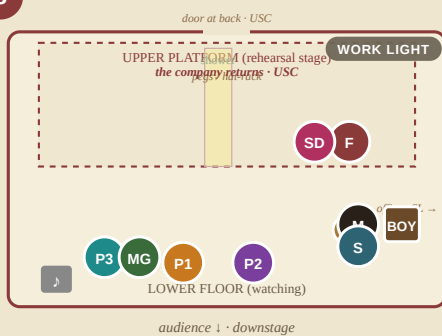
**THE MOTHER** *[rises; one step toward the Son].* My son — *[the Son turns away before the word is finished; she stops].*

7



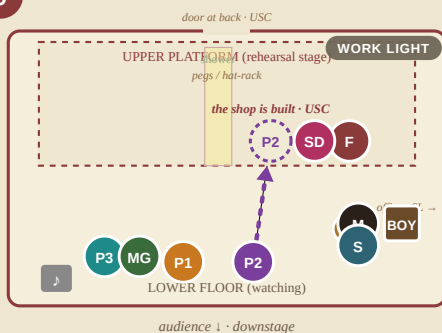
**THE SON** *[half to himself, eyes on the floor].* And they want to put it on the stage. If there was at least a reason for it.

8



*[The stage call-bells ring. From the dressing-rooms and the little door at the back the company returns; the Manager comes out of his office with the Father and the Step-Daughter].*

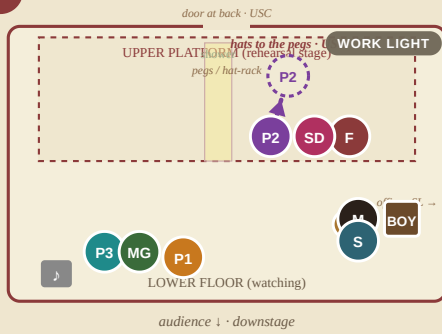
9



**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** And the screen! There must be a screen. Otherwise how am I to manage? **PLAYER 2** *[as Property Man, setting the shop].* That's all right, Miss. We've got any amount of them.

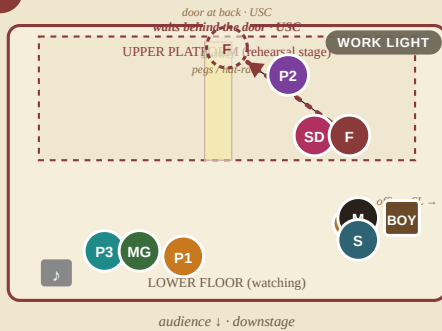
## PART II — THE APPARITION

1



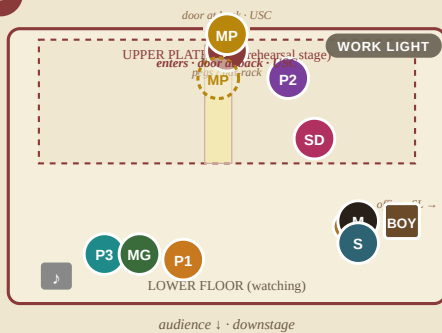
**THE FATHER.** Oh nothing. I just want to put these on the pegs for a moment. *[the actresses give up their hats; the shop window and the screen are set].*

2



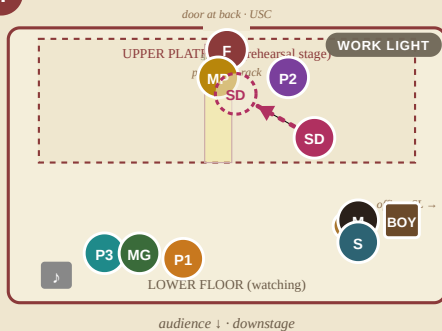
**THE FATHER.** She is alluding to me. I've got to be here — there behind that door, in waiting; and Madame Pace knows it.

3



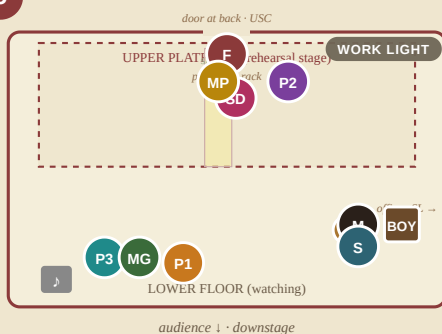
*[The door at the back of stage opens and Madame Pace enters and takes a few steps forward — fat, bleach-blonde, the silver chain at her waist].*

4



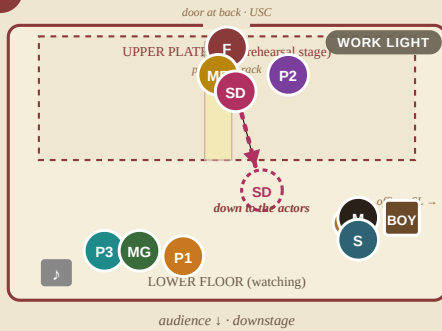
**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[turning towards her, running over].* There she is! There she is!

5



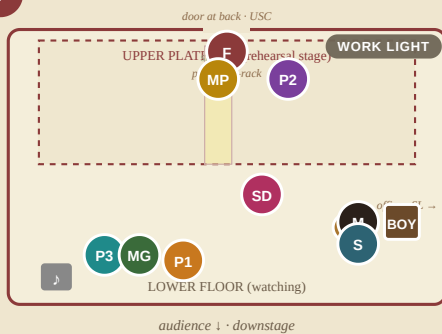
*[Madame Pace places one hand under the Step-Daughter's chin to raise her head].* **MADAME PACE.** Good morning, good morning, sir! Madame Pace, sir — dresses and coats, off the rue de Bourg.

6



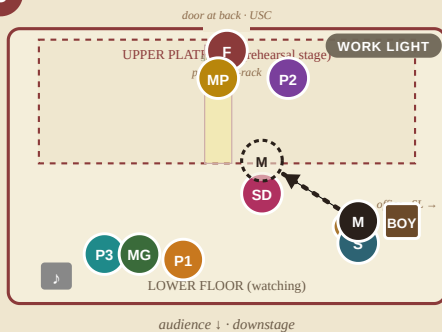
**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** [*leaving Madame Pace and advancing towards the actors*]. Louder? Louder? What on earth are you talking about?

7



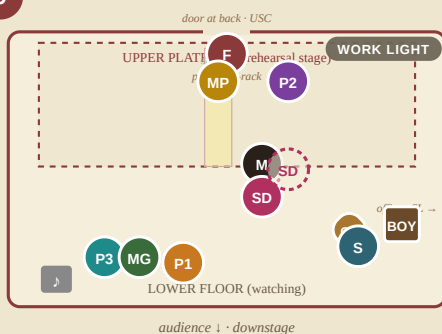
**MADAME PACE** [*the comedy curdling*]. Not so old, my dear. Forty-five, maybe fifty — the age when a man have money in the pocket and shame in the throat, eh, sir?

8



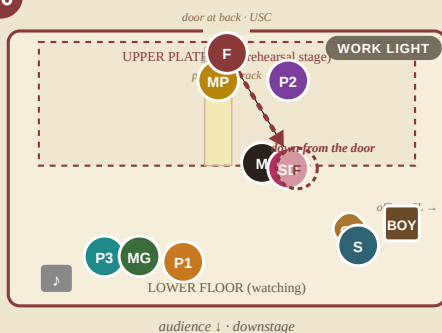
**THE MOTHER** [*jumping up amid the consternation of the actors — the voice she has not used for years*]. You old devil! You murderess!

9



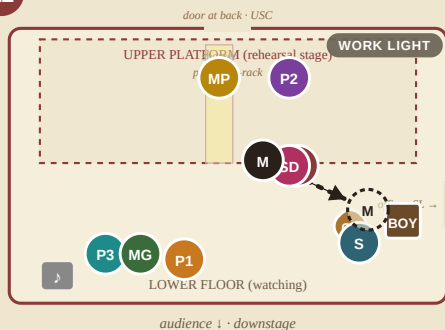
**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** [*running over to calm her Mother*]. Calm yourself, Mother, calm yourself! Please don't...

10



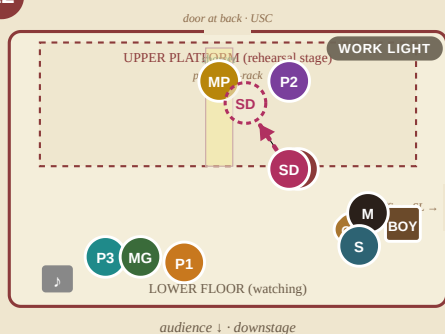
**THE FATHER** [*going to her also, the body beginning to give him away*]. Calm yourself! Don't get excited! Sit down now!

11



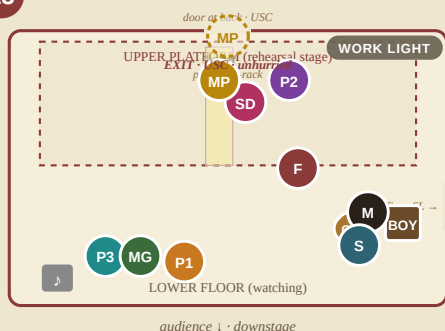
**THE MANAGER** [turning to the Mother and leading her to her chair]. Come along, my dear lady, sit down now, and let's get on with the scene.

12



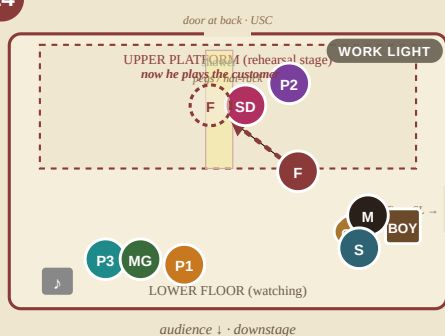
**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** [coming forward again, turns to Madame Pace]. Come on, Madame, come on!

13



**MADAME PACE** [pausing at the door, the smile calm now, almost tender]. There is always the next silk. There is always the debt. There is always Pace. Don't you forget the name. [Exits. Not furious. Unhurried].

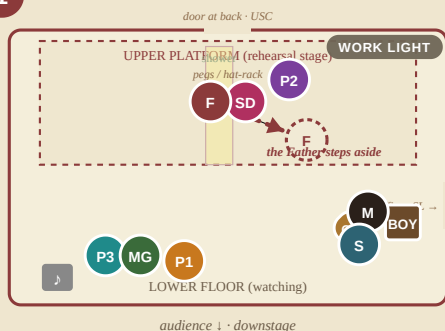
14



**THE FATHER** [coming forward, composed now — this is the scene, this is the man he was]. Good afternoon, Miss.

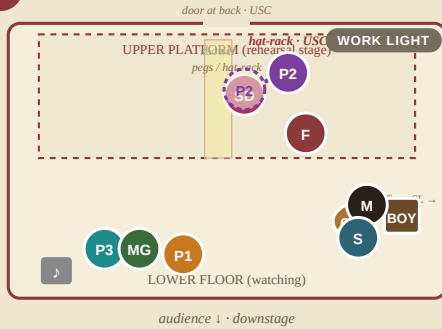
## PART III — THE SUBSTITUTION

1



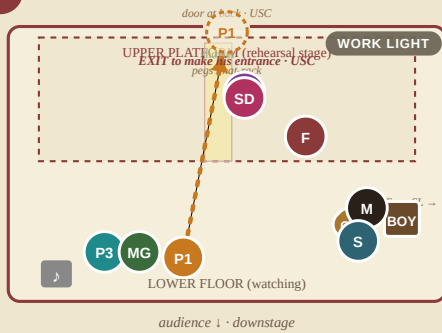
**THE MANAGER** [to the company]. Be quiet, please, and watch — you'll learn something. [Stand aside and let me see the action]. **THE FATHER** [stepping aside to watch his own scene replayed].

2



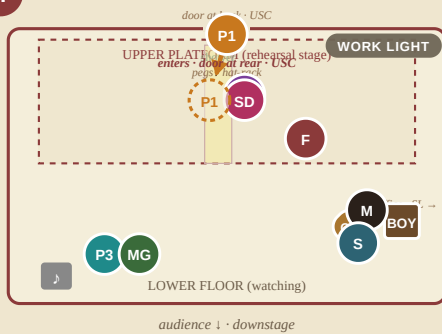
**PLAYER 2** [as Leading Lady; goes over to the hat-rack and puts her hat on, to play the Step-Daughter]. One minute. I want to put my hat on again.

3



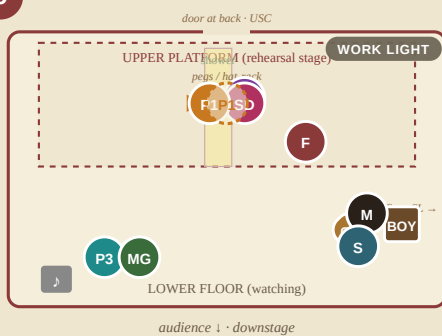
**PLAYER 1** [as Leading Man]. Why, yes! I'll prepare my entrance. [Exit to make his entrance].

4



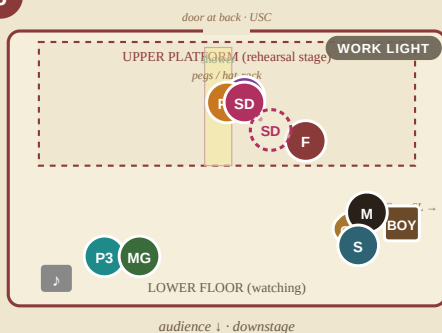
[The door at rear opens and the Leading Man enters with the lively manner of an old gallant]. **PLAYER 1** [as Leading Man]. Good afternoon, Miss.

5



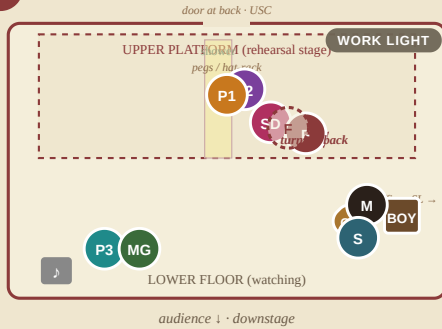
**PLAYER 1** [as Leading Man, a step closer, practised gallantry]. Allow me — I'll put it down for you. But a dear little head like yours should have a smarter hat.

6



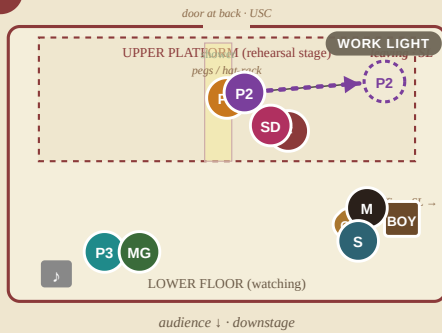
**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** [unable to keep still; advancing toward the actors]. He didn't say "I'm frightfully sorry." He said "Oh." And then he didn't move. His hand stayed on the hat.

7



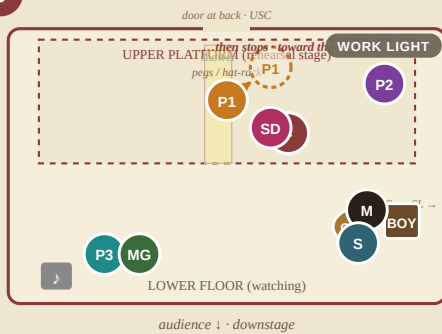
**THE FATHER** *[turning back, quietly]*. Yes. He said “Oh.”

8



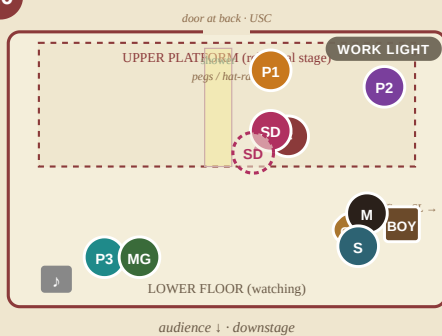
**PLAYER 2** *[the diva's posture going from offended to leaving]*. I am not going to stand here being made a fool of by that woman.

9



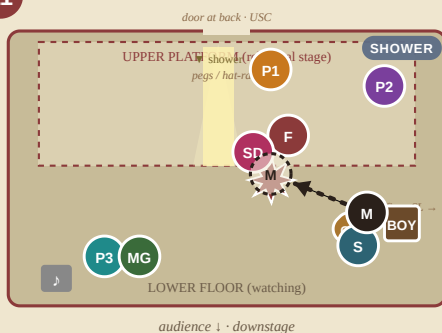
**PLAYER 1** *[as Leading Man; two steps toward the exit — then a calculation crosses his face; he stops]*. Neither am I. I am through with this scene.

10



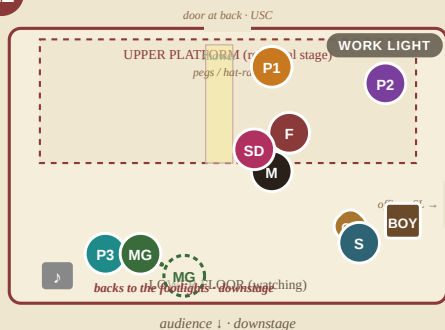
**THE STEP-DAUGHTER**. I can hear it still in my ears — that cry. You may put me on as you like, provided I have that cry. **THE STEP-DAUGHTER**. Cry out, mother. *Cry out as you did then!*

11



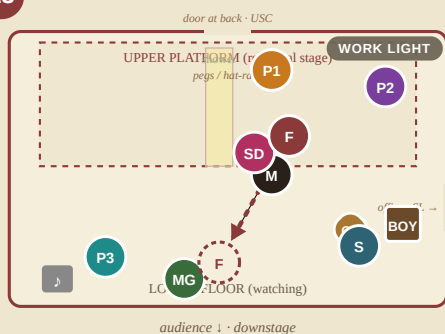
**THE MOTHER** *[coming forward to separate them; the shower falls on her]*. No! My daughter, my daughter! You brute! She is my daughter!

12



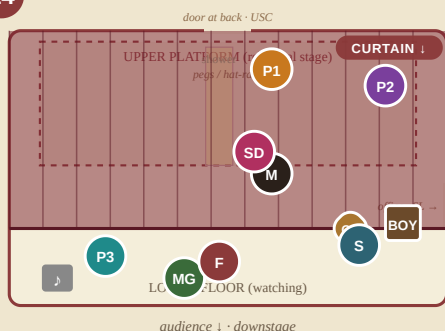
**THE MANAGER** *[walking backwards towards the footlights — the way a satisfied audience member would]*. Fine. Fine! And then we have the curtain there.

13



**THE FATHER** *[going towards him excitedly]*. Yes, of course, because that's the way it really happened.

14

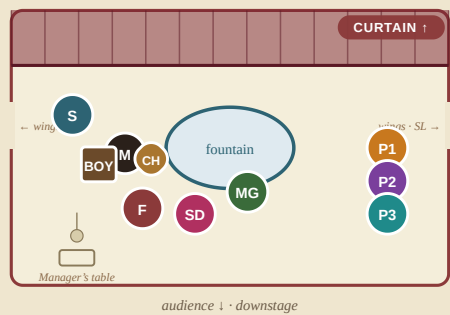


**THE MANAGER**. Oh, yes, no doubt about it. Curtain here, curtain! *[the Machinist lets the curtain down in earnest — the act ends on the curtain's fall]*.

# Act Three — The Question

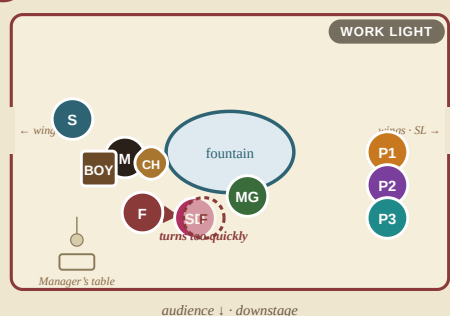
## PART I — THE TRAP

1



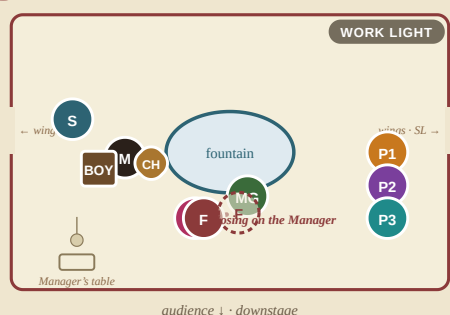
[Curtain up. The two-level set is struck; the stage is bare but for a single fountain basin, centre. The family sit stage-right — the Mother with the Child-bundle in her lap and the Boy-chair against her knee, the Son apart, the Father and Step-Daughter at the right front; the company sit stage-left; the Manager stands centre]. **THE MANAGER.** Ah yes: the second act!

2



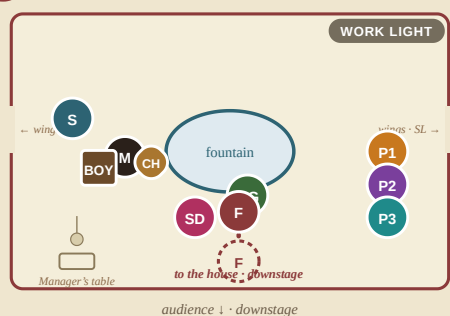
**PLAYER 2** [as Leading Lady]. The audience needs to know which room we are in. **THE FATHER** [the word lands physically — he turns too quickly]. The illusion — for Heaven's sake, don't say illusion. Don't use that word.

3



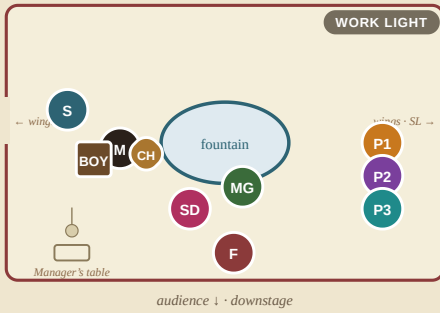
**THE FATHER** [a step or two nearer the Manager; then, slowly, turning out toward the house]. A character, sir, may always ask a man who he is. Because a character really does have a life of his own.

4



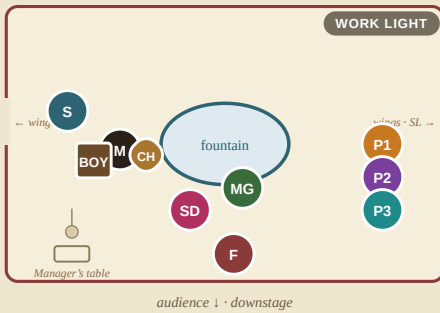
**THE FATHER** [turning full out to the house; a pause long enough to feel]. Can you tell me who you are?

5



**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** [*level, never raised — colder than the philosophy*]. His reality. He always knew exactly where to find me.

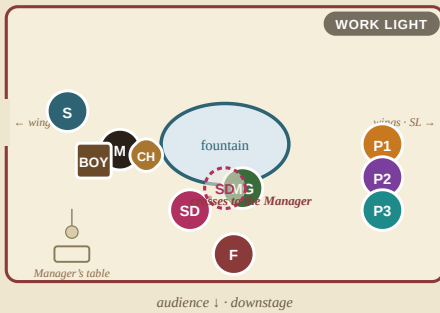
6



**THE MANAGER.** Then you'll be saying you are more true and real than I am? **THE FATHER** [*the greatest seriousness — the cry breaks, then the body goes still*]. But of course. Without doubt.

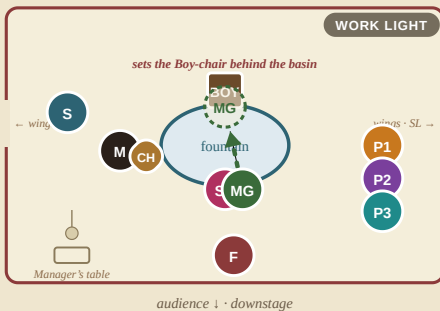
## PART II — THE REFUSAL

1



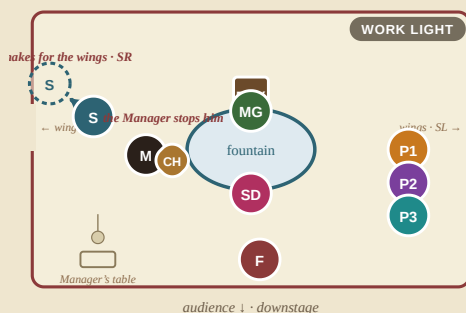
**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** [*goes close to the Manager, as if in confidence*]. In my opinion he abandoned us in a fit of disgust for the ordinary theatre.

2



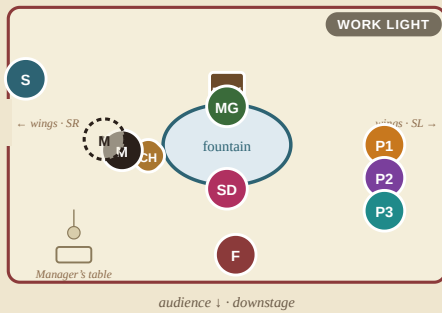
**THE MANAGER** [*he stands; he picks up the Boy-chair himself and walks it across the stage, and places it behind the fountain basin — the pivot of his arc*].

3



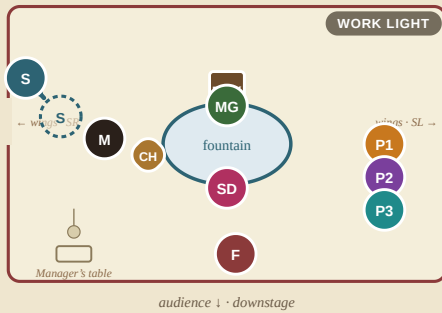
**THE SON** [*jumping up*]. Delighted! I don't ask for anything better. [*begins to move away*] **THE MANAGER** [*at once stopping him*]. No! No! Where are you going? Wait a bit!

4



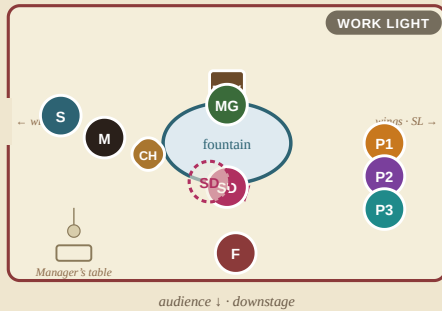
**THE MOTHER** *[gets up, alarmed and terrified that he is really about to go, and instinctively lifts her arms]. [She does not reach him].*

5



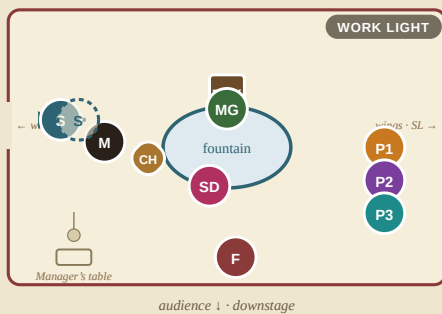
**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[calmly — she knows him].* Don't bother to stop him. He won't go. **THE SON**. I will act nothing at all. I've said so from the very beginning.

6



**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[going over to the Manager, and putting down his arm].* Allow me? Well — go on then. Go away.

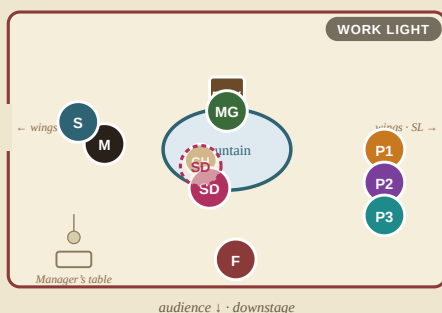
7



**THE SON** *[trapped now, and knowing it].* No. If I can't go away, then I'll stop here. But I repeat — I act nothing. **THE FATHER**. You can force him, sir. **THE FATHER**. I can.

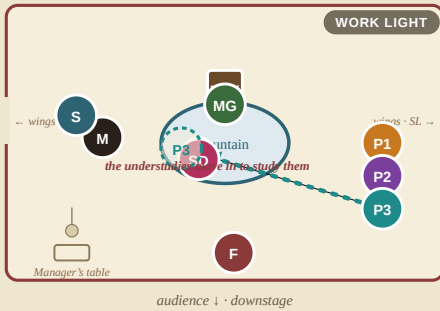
## PART III — THE FOUNTAIN

1



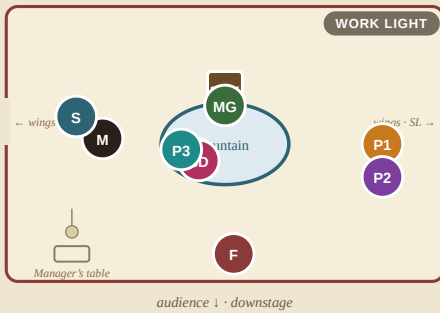
**THE STEP-DAUGHTER**. Wait — first of all, the baby has to go to the fountain... *[lifts the Child-bundle from the Mother's lap and carries it toward the fountain].*

2



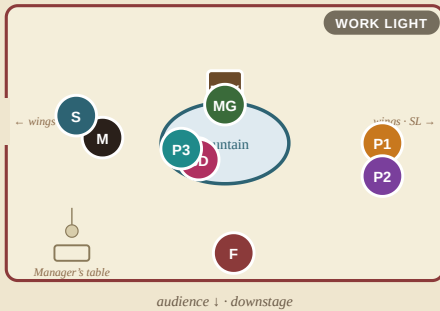
*[The Second Lady Lead and the Juvenile Lead separate themselves from the group of Actors — one watches the Mother attentively, the other studies the movements of the Son he will have to play].*

3



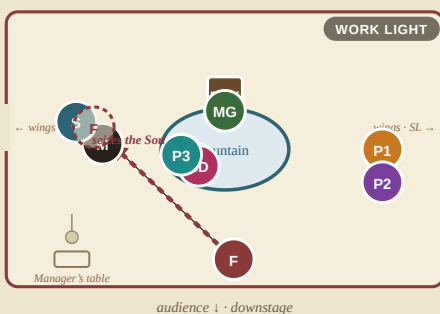
**THE SON** *[the cry he has held the whole production — surprising himself].* Yes — but haven't you yet perceived that it isn't possible to live in front of a mirror that throws our likeness back at us with a horrible grimace?

4



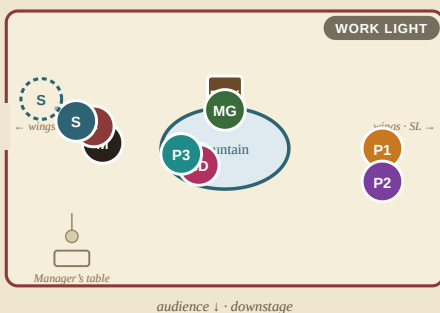
**THE MOTHER.** Yes. Into his room. I couldn't bear it any more. I went to tell him what I have inside me — all of it. *[a hand at her chest]*

5



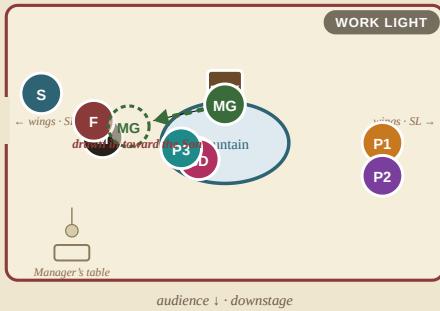
**THE FATHER** *[going to the Son in a great rage, taking hold of him].* You'll do this for your mother, do you understand? You've got to obey, do you hear?

6

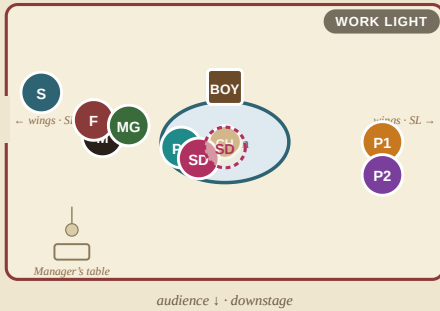


**THE SON** *[taking hold of the Father; then the voice cracks and they separate].* No! No! And for God's sake stop it! What does it mean — this madness you've got?

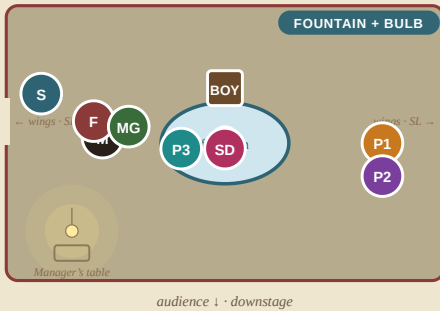
**THE MANAGER** *[coming closer to the Son, interested by his extraordinary reserve].* Well, well... walking in the garden...



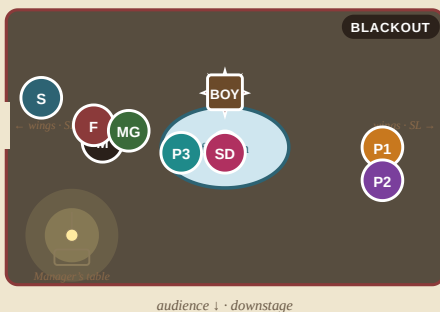
**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** [*bends over the basin and lowers the Child-bundle into it; the basin's walls hide the action from view*].



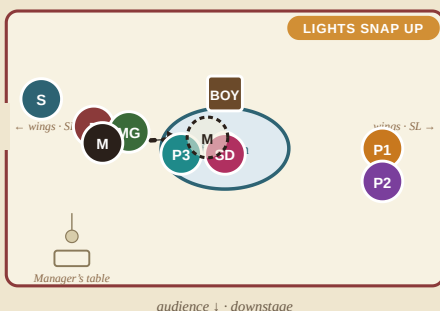
**THE SON** [*this one continuous sentence; the stage lights drop, breath by breath, until only the fountain and the bare bulb over the Manager's table remain — the Boy-chair silhouetted behind the basin*]. There in the fountain...



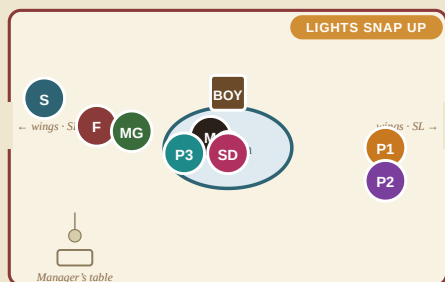
*[Full blackout. Out of the dark, a revolver shot rings out from behind the basin where the Boy-chair is].*



**THE MOTHER** [*she does not cry out at once — she reaches first for the Child-bundle in the basin, then the Boy-chair behind it; her arms cannot hold both, the veil still down*]. My son! My son!



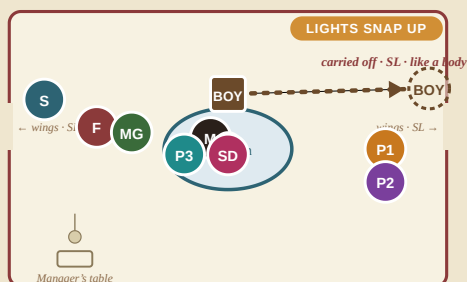
12



audience ↓ · downstage

**TWO PLAYERS.** He's dead! dead! **THE OTHER PLAYERS.** No, no — it's only make-believe, only pretence! **THE FATHER** [*with a terrible cry*]. Pretence? Reality, sir — reality!

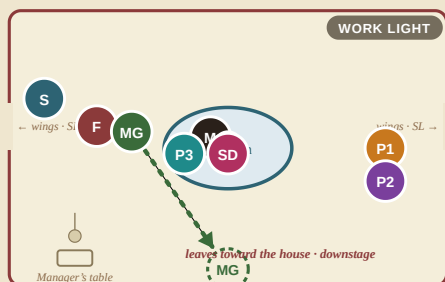
13



audience ↓ · downstage

[*The Players lift up the Boy-chair and carry it off, handling it as if it were the Boy's body — heavy, careful, terrible*].

14



audience ↓ · downstage

**THE MANAGER** [*a look at the place where the Boy-chair stood, then he turns and leaves the stage the way a man leaves a theatre*]. Pretence? Reality? ... To hell with it all.